

yourself a break and head for those places that are most likely to welcome you.

Guadalajara, Rio de Janeiro, and Madrid also have practical advantages. You can fly to any of them on cheap charters or discount fares. You can enter as a tourist and stay for up to six months before having to renew your visa or tourist card. In Guadalajara or Madrid you'll learn Spanish; in Brazil you'll learn Portuguese. Both those languages come from familiar Latin roots, and you can learn them easier than, say, Chinese or Swahili.

Most important, with \$743 a month in those three cities you'll live like the upper middle class and have money left over. As one Guadalajara retiree told *Money* magazine in 1985, "My Social Security check is \$1,100. My rent is \$60. I drink, but I can't drink that much." *Choose Mexico—Retire on \$400 a Month* describes how thousands of Americans live in Mexico on \$400 a month or less. Thousands more live in Rio de Janeiro on \$400 a month. Madrid costs a little more, say \$700 or so, but still falls within your bare-bones budget.

Guadalajara, Mexico, rests high up in Mexico's Central Plateau. Locals claim they live in the best climate in the world, and they may be right. Year-round temperatures stay in the 60s and 70s. Residents build homes without heating and air-conditioning, and rarely take more than a sweater to go out. For warmer weather, they head down the hill to the beach resorts of Manzanillo, San Blas, and Puerto Vallarta, all just a few hours away by bus.

Most Americans in the area—an estimated 30,000 of them—retire on nearby Lake Chapala. But Guadalajara itself is Mexico's second-largest city. With 2.5 million people it offers what we expect of a major metropolitan area: entertainment, museums, good restaurants, excellent medical care and other services, daily newspapers, and good public transportation.

The first time I went to Guadalajara, many years ago, I kept slipping back in time. I pictured a more peaceful world,